

brands even offering the 480 mm radiators. Needless to say, you need to ensure that your cabinet can fit the radiators which end up taking a lot more space than the CPU blocks. Moreover, the fans are affixed to the radiators, so when considering the thickness of the radiators, you need to account for the cumulative thickness of the radiator block as well as the cooling fan.

The radiator blocks are affixed to the CPU block by means of two pipes which carry the coolant. The length of these tubes are generally around 15-inches or so. So the usual mounting spots for a radiator are either on the top of the cabinet or towards the front of the cabinet. If the radiator is small, i.e. 120mm, then you can even mount it on the rear of the cabinet.



120mm radiator mounted on the rear



Radiator and fans on the same side

Often you will see that cabinets mention that they have liquid cooling support. This means that the cabinet will have a proper mounting spot for these radiators. Do note that having grommets on cabinets are useless when you're considering AIOs since such coolers are sealed and you cannot detach the tubing in order to route it through the grommets holes.

A simple rule of the thumb for checking if you have radiator support is to see if the clearance between the top of the motherboard and the top of the cabinet is enough to fit the radiator and the cooling fans. Sometimes, the radiator is mounted on the inside of the cabinet with the cooling fans being mounted outside the cabinet.

Do note, that in the above image, the radiator could be installed on the outside because of a wide opening right above the 5.25-inch drive bays. Most cases don't have a cut out in this location and hence, such mounting is not